



Mexican selling baskets, Puerto Escondido

TOURIST INDUSTRY

One of Mexico's largest employment sectors is tourism. The tourists are attracted by the numerous beautiful beaches on both the Pacific and Caribbean coasts, as well as Mexico's rich blend of history and culture. Popular tourist sites include the archaeological remains of the Aztec and Mayan civilizations, such as the Mayan ruins of the city of Palenque.

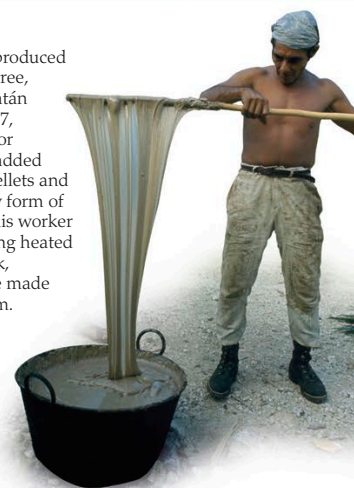


FAMILY TIES

Mexico has a large population, almost half of which are 24 years old or younger. Very often extended families live together in one house, with the mother at the center of the family. Mother's Day remains one of the most important dates in the Mexican calendar.

CHEWING GUM

Chicle is a latex produced by the sapodilla tree, native to the Yucatán Peninsula. In 1867, American inventor Thomas Adams added sugar to chicle pellets and invented an early form of chewing gum. This worker (right) is stretching heated chicle with a stick, preparing it to be made into chewing gum.



MEDIEVAL RULERS

The Aztecs ruled a large part of this region from about 1428 until 1521, when they were conquered by the Spanish. Their capital, Tenochtitlán, was located on the site that is now Mexico City. The influence of this great civilization has left its mark on Mexico – more than 1 million Mexicans speak Nahuatl, the native Aztec language. This feather headdress is thought to have belonged to Moctezuma, the last Aztec ruler.



Aztec headdress

Mexico is the world's main producer of silver, which is mined in the center of the country.



Gulf of Mexico

Bay of Campeche

Istmo de Tehuantepec

Gulf of Tehuantepec

